# What to charge per minute

Channel by channel, scenario by scenario · 13 October 2026 · USD 1 = Rs 278

**An inbound WhatsApp call costs us Rs 3.52 a minute.** The cheapest competitor charges Rs 22.24 a minute all-in and most charge Rs 38.92. We can price at Rs 13.90 to Rs 18.07 a minute, undercut every one of them by half, and still keep three quarters of the revenue.

**Outbound SIM calling is the opposite.** At the only published Pakistan rate we can cite, the carrier alone is Rs 50.04 a minute — 14 times what the AI costs. Until Infobip gives us their rate, outbound SIM should be sold at cost plus a margin, never bundled into a flat per-minute price.

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## 1. The five ways a call can happen

They do not cost remotely the same. Every row is a three-minute call on a trimmed knowledge base, at 40% agent talk time.

| Channel | Carrier per minute | 3-minute call | Our cost per minute | Where the rate comes from |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| WhatsApp call — they call us | Rs 0.00 | Rs 10.55 | **Rs 3.52** | Meta: user-initiated calls are free |
| SIM call — they call us | Rs 1.11 | Rs 13.89 | **Rs 4.63** | Inbound minutes are cheap everywhere |
| WhatsApp call — we call them | Rs 3.17 | Rs 20.06 | **Rs 6.69** | Meta connectivity fee, Asia-Pacific band |
| SIM call — we call them (Infobip best case) | Rs 1.71 | Rs 15.69 | **Rs 5.23** | Top of Infobip's indicative range |
| SIM call — we call them (Twilio published) | Rs 50.04 | Rs 160.67 | **Rs 53.56** | The only citable Pakistan mobile rate |

The two shaded rows are the business. Inbound costs almost nothing beyond the AI, because neither Meta nor a carrier charges much to receive. **Margin is easiest on calls that come to us.**

### Messages

| Message type | Meta charge | Google charge | Total | Total on Flash-Lite |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Reply inside the 24-hour window | Rs 0.00 | Rs 1.68 | Rs 1.68 | **Rs 0.38** |
| Utility template | Rs 2.78 | Rs 1.68 | Rs 4.46 | **Rs 3.16** |
| Marketing template | Rs 13.15 | Rs 1.68 | Rs 14.83 | **Rs 13.53** |

Meta charges nothing for a reply inside 24 hours of the customer's last message, which is exactly what auto-reply does. That makes an answered WhatsApp conversation cost us Rs 0.38 — effectively free. Marketing is the expensive one and should never sit inside a subscription.

## 2. Who brings the credentials

The product already supports all of this: a number carries its own provider credentials, and the operator can allow a company to run on the platform's instead. The commercial difference between those two settings is larger than it looks.

| Scenario | What they bring | Who pays the telecom | Our exposure | What to charge |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **A. Fully their own** | Their Meta app and their Infobip account | They do, directly to the provider | None | Flat platform fee plus a per-minute AI fee |
| **B. Their WhatsApp, our SIM** | Their Meta app only | They pay Meta; we pay Infobip | Carrier minutes | Platform, AI, and carrier at cost plus margin |
| **C. We provide everything** | Nothing | We pay both, and the number rental | All of it | Platform, AI, all pass-through, plus a setup fee |
| **D. WhatsApp only, their number** | Their Meta app | They pay Meta for templates | None | Platform plus a per-message AI fee |
| **E. WhatsApp only, our number** | Nothing | We pay Meta for everything | Template fees | Platform, AI, templates at cost plus margin |

### What each scenario actually costs us

For a company doing 500 three-minute calls and 2,000 answered messages a month, on a trimmed knowledge base and Flash-Lite:

| Scenario | AI cost | Telecom we absorb | Total monthly cost |
|---|---|---|---|
| A. Fully their own | Rs 6,027 | Rs 0.00 | **Rs 6,027** |
| B. Their WhatsApp, our SIM (Infobip best case) | Rs 6,027 | Rs 2,568 | **Rs 8,595** |
| B. Their WhatsApp, our SIM (at Twilio's rate) | Rs 6,027 | Rs 75,060 | **Rs 81,087** |
| C. We provide everything (Infobip best case) | Rs 6,027 | Rs 2,568 | **Rs 8,595** |
| D. WhatsApp only, their number | Rs 6,027 | Rs 0.00 | **Rs 6,027** |
| E. WhatsApp only, our number | Rs 6,027 | Rs 0.00 | **Rs 6,027** |

Scenarios A and D cost us the same, because the only thing we pay for is the AI. **They are also where our price can be lowest, because there is no telecom to recover.** That is an argument for actively encouraging customers to bring their own Infobip account, not merely permitting it.

Scenario C needs a setup fee. Buying and verifying a number, registering a Meta app and getting a template approved is work that happens once and takes days. Charge for it separately; it is not a per-minute cost.

## 3. What the competition charges

These are the platforms a customer would compare us against. All price per minute, and all are US-centric, which is why the rupee equivalents look high.

| Platform | Advertised | All-in per minute | What is included |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Vapi** | Rs 13.90/min | Rs 22.24 to Rs 41.70 | Platform fee only; LLM and telephony on top |
| **Retell AI** | Rs 15.29/min | Rs 29.19 to Rs 43.09 | Voice infrastructure; LLM and telephony on top |
| **Bland AI** | Rs 38.92/min | Rs 38.92 | All-in on the Start tier, no monthly fee |
| **Synthflow** | Rs 41.70/min | Rs 41.70 to Rs 66.72 | Self-serve tiers reportedly withdrawn |
| **Us, inbound WhatsApp** | **Rs 3.52/min** | **Rs 3.52** | **Everything. No carrier leg, no platform fee to anyone** |

The advertised figure is never the whole bill on those platforms: Vapi's Rs 13.90 and Retell's Rs 15.29 are hosting fees with the language model and the telephony charged on top. Ours is the whole cost, because we hold the Google key and the customer holds the carrier account.

**Why we are cheaper, structurally:** Gemini Live is priced well below the stacked speech-to-text, language model and text-to-speech pipelines those platforms resell; inbound WhatsApp has no carrier leg at all; and we pay nobody a platform margin. None of that is a discount we are choosing to give — it is a lower cost base.

## 4. Recommended prices

Sold per minute, with WhatsApp and SIM priced separately, because they cost us different amounts. Pricing them the same either overcharges the WhatsApp customer or loses money on the SIM one.

### Voice, per minute

| Product | Our cost | Price | Margin | Cheapest rival |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| WhatsApp — inbound | Rs 3.52 | **Rs 13.90** | 75% | Rs 22.24 to Rs 38.92 |
| WhatsApp — outbound | Rs 6.69 | **Rs 18.07** | 63% | Rs 22.24 to Rs 38.92 |
| SIM — inbound | Rs 4.63 | **Rs 16.68** | 72% | Rs 22.24 to Rs 38.92 |
| SIM — outbound | carrier plus Rs 3.52 | **carrier at cost plus Rs 13.90** | fixed | carrier dominates |

At Rs 13.90 a minute we are under two thirds of the cheapest all-in rival and under a third of Bland. There is no need to go lower; going lower buys nothing but a thinner cushion against the rupee.

### Messages

| Product | Our cost | Price | Margin |
|---|---|---|---|
| Answered message, inside the 24-hour window | Rs 0.38 | **Rs 1.11** | 66% |
| Utility template sent | Rs 3.16 | **Rs 5.00** | 37% |
| Marketing template sent | Rs 13.53 | **Rs 18.07** | 25% |

### Monthly plans built on those rates

| Plan | Included | Our cost | Price | Margin |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Starter** | 300 min + 1,000 msgs | Rs 4,378 | **Rs 25,000** | 82% |
| **Growth** | 1,500 min + 5,000 msgs | Rs 10,101 | **Rs 95,000** | 89% |
| **Business** | 6,000 min + 20,000 msgs | Rs 31,565 | **Rs 330,000** | 90% |

Costed on inbound WhatsApp, a trimmed knowledge base and Flash-Lite, with the Rs 14,734 monthly platform floor split five ways. Minutes beyond the bundle bill at the per-minute rate above. SIM minutes are an add-on with the carrier passed through, never inside these bundles.

## 5. The one number that can break this

Everything above assumes calls are inbound, or on WhatsApp. Outbound SIM is the exception, and its cost is the one figure nobody has been able to give us.

Infobip does not publish per-destination voice rates. Their rate and balance endpoints both return 404 on our api-pk2 instance, and our own call logs came back empty, so there is nothing to read a real price from. What follows is what a three-minute outbound SIM call costs at a range of carrier rates, so the answer can be read off the moment you have it.

| If the carrier charges | 3-minute call | Our cost per minute | Margin at Rs 13.90/min | Verdict |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Rs 0.56/min — very cheap local wholesale | Rs 12.22 | Rs 4.07 | **71%** | healthy |
| Rs 1.39/min — Infobip indicative top end | Rs 14.72 | Rs 4.91 | **65%** | healthy |
| Rs 2.78/min — a realistic local CPaaS rate | Rs 18.89 | Rs 6.30 | **55%** | healthy |
| Rs 5.56/min | Rs 27.23 | Rs 9.08 | **35%** | thin |
| Rs 13.90/min | Rs 52.25 | Rs 17.42 | **-25%** | LOSS |
| Rs 50.04/min — Twilio's published Pakistan mobile | Rs 160.67 | Rs 53.56 | **-285%** | LOSS |

**The break-even is Rs 10.38 a minute.** Above that, a flat Rs 13.90 per minute loses money on every outbound SIM call. Twilio's published rate is 5 times the break-even, which is why outbound SIM cannot go on a flat rate until the real Infobip number is known.

### What to do about it

1. **Get the rate.** It is in the Infobip portal under Billing, or from the account manager: ask for Pakistan mobile and landline termination per minute, and whether billing is per second or per minute.

2. **Until then, sell outbound SIM at cost plus a fixed margin** rather than a flat per-minute price. The customer sees the carrier line separately, and a rate change does not eat our margin.

3. **Push customers towards their own Infobip account** for outbound volume. It removes the risk entirely, and the product already supports it.

4. **Lead with inbound and WhatsApp.** That is where the cost advantage actually lives, and it needs no carrier negotiation at all.

## 6. Two changes worth more than any price rise

**Switch the text model.** The build uses gemini-3.5-flash at $1.50 and $9.00 per million. Flash-Lite is $0.30 and $2.50. On the University knowledge base that is Rs 10.22 a message against Rs 2.08 — 80% off the largest variable cost we have.

**Trim the knowledge bases.** The whole base is re-sent on every call and every message. The University base costs Rs 4.96 per call where the Jazz base costs Rs 0.79. Halving a base halves that line forever.

Together they take a message from Rs 10.22 to Rs 0.38, a factor of 27. No price change available to us moves the business that much.

## 7. What could not be proven

| Figure | Status | How to settle it |
|---|---|---|
| Infobip Pakistan voice rate | **Unknown** | The Infobip portal under Billing, or the account manager |
| Meta WhatsApp calling rate for Pakistan | Regional proxy | Pakistan is not in the published rate card; Rs 3.17 is the Afghanistan and Bangladesh rate |
| gemini-3.5-flash price | Aggregators only | Not on Google's own price list, which is itself a reason to switch |
| Competitor all-in rates | Secondary | Advertised platform fees are first-party; the all-in bands are third-party analyses and differ between sources |
| Render Starter and Standard prices | Secondary | Their pricing page would not render; several write-ups agree |
| EUR/PKR at 317 | Stale | A July 2026 figure, used only for Infobip's small add-on charges |

Everything else — the Meta message rates, the token counts, the Google audio rates — is either read from our own account or taken from a first-party price list.

## 8. Sources

### First-party, and our own account

- Meta per-message rates — pricing_analytics on WhatsApp Business Account 2812213305655211, 90 days to 13 Oct 2026, giving $0.0473 marketing and $0.0100 utility
- Gemini Developer API pricing — ai.google.dev/gemini-api/docs/pricing — the live model's audio and text rates, and 25 tokens per second
- WhatsApp Calling API pricing — developers.facebook.com — user-initiated calls free, billed in six-second pulses
- Twilio Voice pricing for Pakistan — twilio.com/voice/pricing/pk — $0.18 mobile, $0.155 landline, $0.004 to receive
- Infobip voice pricing — infobip.com/voice/pricing — add-on rates only, and confirmation that destination rates are not published
- Token counts — Google's count_tokens against this deployment's real assembled prompts

### Secondary

- Competitor per-minute rates — vendor pages and comparison analyses including famulor.io, leadlock.ai and tested.media; the all-in bands are estimates and differ between sources
- gemini-3.5-flash at $1.50 and $9.00 — pricepertoken.com and anotherwrapper.com, agreeing, citing Google's docs
- Infobip indicative voice band of EUR 0.0002 to 0.0054 — checkthat.ai, which does not name Pakistan
- USD/PKR 278 — Pakistan Observer, 9 Oct 2026. EUR/PKR 317 — Pluang, 22 Jul 2026

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Every figure is computed by docs/build_pricing_report.py. Change the exchange rate, the talk ratio, the carrier rate or a knowledge base size at the top of that file and re-run it; the whole document moves with it.